

TABLE II
Start-up Monthly Subscription Rates

DTH service provider	Rate (Rs)	Number of channels
Airtel Digital TV	178	76
Dish TV	180	135
Reliance Digital TV	171	74
Tata Sky	180	59
Videocon D2H	183	111

one broadcaster to another.

Place a bet on a DTH service that offers maximum number of your favourite channels (sports, music, news, entertainment, lifestyle, etc). Airtel Digital TV leads the pack with 332 channels, followed by Videocon D2H (330), Tata Sky (316), Dish TV (310) and Reliance Digital TV (300). The numbers herein jointly comprise video as well as audio (radio) and data channels.

Various DTH service providers offer channel-packs categorised by price denominations and content genres. Only Dish TV, Airtel DTH and Tata Sky give you the freedom to create your own customised packs by choosing channels.

HD channels

The demand for HD movies, television content and games is increasing. Going with the flow, DTH operators have also pulled up their socks to gain the most from this demand. With 15 true HD channels, Airtel Digital TV is in the lead. Videocon D2H with 13 comes next, followed by Dish TV (10), Tata Sky (8) and Reliance Digital TV (7).

Only a few channels are broadcast in HD format. DTH operators like Reliance Digital TV, Dish TV and Airtel Digital TV broadcast channels in up-scale Standard Definition (SD), which gives a digitally enhanced version of the original quality. But be careful as at times, companies use misleading terms such as HD-like and near-HD.

To view HD channels, primarily you need to upgrade from an SD set-top box to an HD set-top box. You also need to have an HD-capable TV set.

TABLE III
HD Channels Offered by DTH TV Operators

DTH service provider	Number of HD channels offered	Channels
Airtel Digital TV	16	STAR Plus, Zee TV, Colors, STAR World, STAR Gold, Zee Cinema, Movies Now, STAR Movies, ESPN, STAR Cricket, SET Max, Ten Sports, History, TV 18, Discovery World, National Geographic
Dish TV	10	Colors, Movies Now, TravelXP, UTV Stars, Discovery World, National Geographic, History, CNBC TV 18, Ten Sports, M Tunes
Reliance Digital TV	7	STAR Plus, Zee TV, STAR Gold, STAR Movies, ESPN, STAR Cricket, National Geographic
Tata Sky	8	STAR Gold, STAR Movies, Discovery World, ESPN, National Geographic, STAR Cricket, STAR World, STAR Plus
Videocon D2H	13	STAR Plus, Colors, Zee TV, STAR Gold, ESPN, STAR Cricket, Ten Sports, SET Max, Movies Now, STAR Movies, STAR World, National Geographic, Discovery World

TABLE IV
Some HD Recorders

DTH service provider	Price of HD Recorder (Rs)	Additional features
Airtel Digital TV	5990	HD recording duration 550 hours, 3D ready, set-top box can be instructed to record shows via your mobile phone
Dish TV	2290	No internal storage, unlimited recording via USB storage device
Reliance Digital TV	4890	HD recording duration of up to 200 hours, 160GB storage, 3D ready
Tata Sky	5940	HD recording duration of 425 hours, 500GB storage
Videocon D2H	4490	HD recording duration of up to 200 hours, doubles as a DVD player, 3D ready

Apart from Dish TV, all DTH service providers are 3D-ready, amongst which only Videocon D2H offers a Singapore-based 3D channel. As in the case of HD, you need to have a 3D-enabled TV set and a pair of 3D glasses to enjoy content in 3D.

Recorder

Today, almost every player in the market has a digital video recorder (DVR) model in its bouquet of STBs. When compared with regular STBs, the DVR-based models can be a little expensive but these can be programmed to record your favourite TV shows when you are away from home.

Other interactive features

A host of DTH players offer interactive services across domains like education, games, cooking and astrology. For instance, Tata Sky offers Active Darshan as part of its interactive services, which allows users to access videos shot at various spiritual destinations.

Service providers also offer the feature of video on demand, using which subscribers can watch movies, TV serials and other content for a fee.

The road ahead: Digitisation

Most cable operators in the country provide analogue TV services. As per new guidelines by the government of India, all analogue cable services should be digitised in the cities of Delhi, Mumbai, Kolkata and Chennai by July 2012. This means that people availing the age-old analogue cable TV services will have to switch to a digital set-top box to continue watching television.

Foreseeing an advantageous opportunity ahead, DTH operators may possibly hike prices when digitisation comes into effect. Hence it would be a wise decision to get 'dished' before it's too late. ●

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